

MILIND SHELTE

gramming czarina Ekta Kapoor joined the field in 2017, launching her own platform in AltBalaji to create shows she knew wouldn't fit family-friendly TV.

As the Covid-19 pandemic cooped up people in their homes, the advantages of signing up for streaming became more apparent. The Indian viewer was now not only well-versed with the entertainment goings-on across the globe, she was also curious about Indian content in other languages. Easy access to subtitles and dubbed content in multiple Indian languages meant that once-impassable linguistic boundaries stood erased. By 2023, regional OTT content had exceeded that in Hindi—of the 3,000 hours of original content produced, 52 per cent was in regional languages—as per Ernst & Young's annual report.

"OTTs have revolutionised the entertainment industry by democratising access for audiences and creators alike. It's no longer about rigid schedules—viewers can now enjoy high-quality content like TVF's *Aspirants* and *Kota Factory*, at their convenience," says Vijay Koshy, president, TVF. He says that OTTs have ushered in "a golden era" of showcasing authentic stories. Citing Malayalam cinema, Koshy points out how audiences are discovering such cinema due to OTTs. "This synergy is reshaping entertainment, making meaningful storytelling accessible to everyone," says Koshy.

As internet penetration continues to increase, the OTT boom isn't going away. Today, an estimated 100 million Indians have embraced OTT platforms, many of them taking at least two or more subscriptions. Adventurous, knowledgeable, harder to please and hungry for more, the OTT viewer is taking the Indian entertainment industry in newer, ingenious directions. ■

HOW IT TRANSFORMED MY LIFE

"OTTs changed my viewing habits"

SHRUTI UNAVANE, 26
Banker, Mumbai

Shruti Unavane is clear about her choices, saying she prefers OTT over cable TV and cinemas. "Why will I spend Rs 1,200 on monthly cable subscription to watch what TV channels are showing and where I don't have the option to watch I want? It's better to subscribe to Netflix, Amazon Prime, ZEE5, Hotstar and Jio Cinema which gives me the liberty to see what and when I want to." With "not many films worthy of making a trip to cinemas", Unavane would rather wait for the films to come on OTT a few weeks later. "I'd rather sit at home, dim my lights, order whatever I want or cook what I feel, and comfortably watch from my sofa-cum-bed on my 43-inch TV," she says. It's not just the convenience of watching from home, the fact that she can also continue viewing shows from where she left off on her mobile is a big draw as well. Then there are the endless options streaming offers. "OTTs have changed my viewing habits a lot. I used to never watch South Indian films. Now, I like watching their versions dubbed in Hindi," she says. ■